

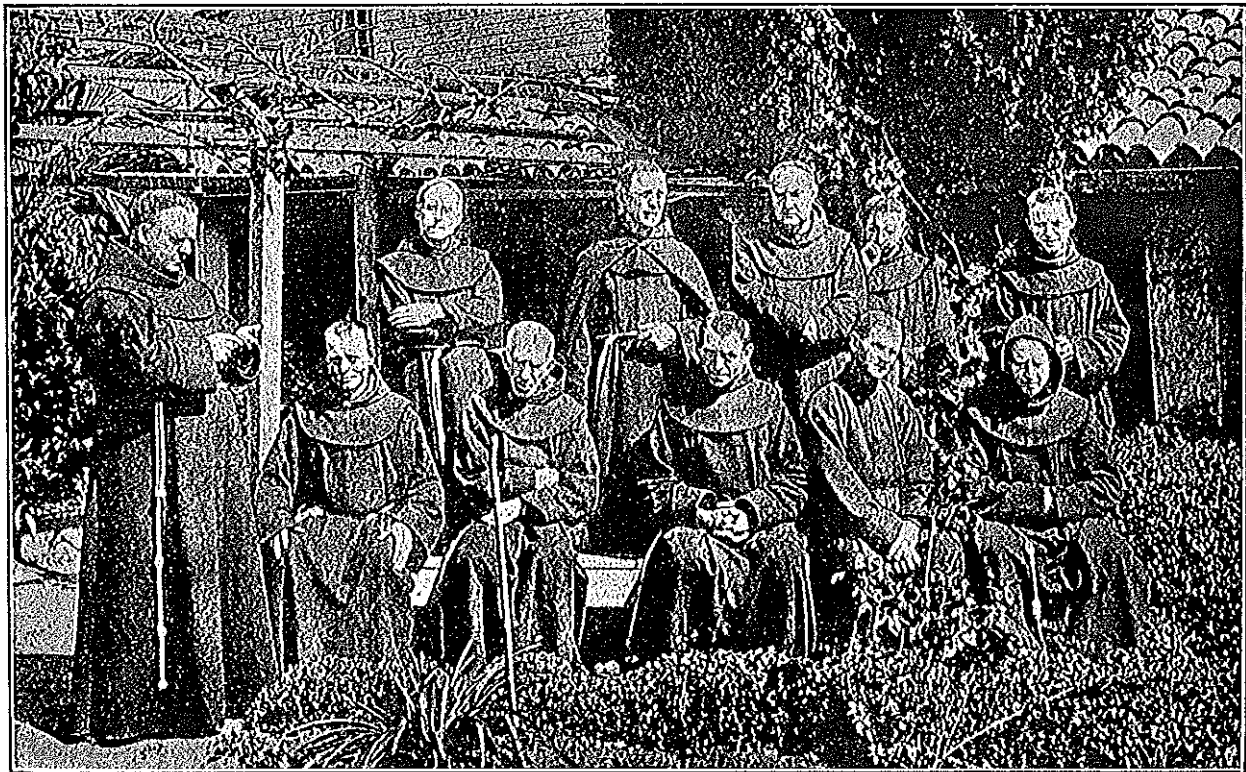
Sacpili,	Yuyunachet,	202
Alcas,	Sumumaguit,	51
Gelijec,	Ajuiait,	66
Geloo,	Guiguinahuit,	101
Mignigui (dos pueblos),	Yguamaita,	
	Tenuaquiachet,	210
Casil (is new),	Siesanapauet,	142
La Quemada,	Suigulaiasu,	250
La Gaviota,	Asiquiyaut,	30
El Bulito (Estait),	Tulalu,	68
Sta. Tescas,	Suluguapuyaut,	30
El Cojo Sisilopo,	Cuyayamahuit,	72
Espada,	Siguiguimacita,	12
Pedernales,	Noctó,	12

H.

THE LONE WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS ISLAND.

In the latter part of the nineteenth century much was written and printed about an Indian woman said to have been rescued from one of the Santa Barbara Channel Islands. We have before us three different versions which agree on the main points, but vary in details. In brief, the story is to the effect that in 1835 the Fathers of Santa Barbara Mission had the *Peor es Nada* (Worse is Nothing), Captain Charles Hubbard, sail over to San Nicolas Island, the farthest from the mainland, in order to bring the islanders to the coast. The weather was stormy when the vessel reached the island. The Indians, about twenty in number, were hurried into the boats, and all speed was made to reach the schooner. In the excitement a child was left behind which the mother supposed had been carried aboard in the arms of a sailor. The frantic mother implored the men to return. The captain, however, replied that he must reach a place of safety, but that later they would go back for the baby. Thereupon, the mother, a widow of about twenty-five years of age, jumped overboard and struck out through the kelpy waters for the island shore. In a moment she was lost in the seething waves. The ship with the affrighted islanders huddled together on deck staggered through the boiling waves and storm, and eventually reached San Pedro. Some of the Indians were sent to Los Angeles, others went to San Gabriel. Captain Hubbard wanted to return to San Nicolas Island, but the ship was in demand on the coast, and so the woman and her babe were forgotten.

Their uncertain fate lay heavy on the kind-hearted Mission Fathers;



STANDING: FR. O'KEEFE, BR. LEO, FR. KILIAN, FR. RAYNER, BR. FAUSTIN, BR. ALOYS.
SEATED: BROS. GODFREY, ANT. GALLAGHER, HUGOLIN, IVO, PETER HABERLIN.—1889.

but it was not till 1850 that Fr. González Rúbio found a man, Thomas Jeffries, who for \$200 agreed to visit the island and bring over the woman and child. He made the attempt, but found no living being on the island. In the following year, George Nidever of Santa Barbara, a convert to the Catholic Faith, accompanied by Jeffries and a crew of Indians, sailed over to San Nicolas, and remained there six weeks without discovering any trace of the woman. In 1852 another unsuccessful trip was made. In July, 1853, Mr. Nidever made one more attempt in company with Carl Ditman, *alias* Charlie Brown, an Irish cook, and a crew of Mission Indians. This time the woman was discovered, and willingly came along to Santa Barbara, where Nidever had his family care for her in his own house. Whatever her language, no one could be found along the coast who understood her, nor could she make out what was said to her in Spanish or in any of the dialects spoken among the shore Indians. So she managed to make herself understood by means of signs. When discovered she wore a gown made of bird skins and feathers. On shore she enjoyed her new life, and displayed no symptoms of ferocity. She would go around to different homes and dance Indian dances, Mr. Nidever relates. Clothes were her especial delight. Unfortunately, change of diet cut short the life of Juana Maria; for under that name she was conditionally baptized by Father Sanchez, according to Brown. She would doubtless have lived many years, had some caution been exercised with regard to her food; but she was supplied to her heart's content with dainty foods, from which she gradually sickened and died. It was also claimed that Juana Maria after her death found her resting-place in the cemetery of Santa Barbara Mission. Such is the story in brief of the Lone Woman of San Nicolas Island.

Were it not that Mr. Nidever's fame for veracity appears above suspicion, we should declare the whole story a myth, for the reason that, after a close examination of the Baptismal Registers at the Mission and at the Parish Church of Santa Barbara, we failed to discover any entry recording the woman's Baptism in either the Mission or the Parish Church. Likewise, there is no record noted of her burial in the Mission Cemetery.

"That the story is literally true," writes Stephen Bowers in the *Ventura Observer*, December 20, 1892, "there can be no doubt whatever. We received it from Captain Nidever's own lips several years before his death. The writer was personally acquainted with him from 1874 until his death which occurred about 1886. He was much respected in Santa Barbara, where he lived more than fifty years. We never heard his integrity called in question by anyone. . . . The account may also be found in the archives of the Santa Barbara Mission, preserved by the Mission Fathers. We secured a translation of

their record of the event by a competent Spanish scholar fifteen years ago."

Bancroft corroborates what Mr. Bowers says of Mr. Nidever; but the last statement regarding the presence in the Mission Archives of a paper or document containing the story of the Lone Woman we cannot verify. We found no such account among the numerous papers in the Mission Archives nor anywhere else.



BROTHER PETER HABERLIN, THE LAST
SURVIVOR OF FR. SANCHEZ'S NOVICES.